composed a report for Moscow. Anatoly Dobrynin spent twenty-four years as ambassador in Washington: he was one of the most experienced and effective Soviet diplomats of the Cold War, and played a key role in intricate arms control negotiations between Moscow and Washington over several decades. His telegram to the Foreign Ministry on 27 October 1962 would have presumably been crafted with great care. It was first published in Lebow and Stein's *We All Lost the Cold War* in 1994.[65]

Dobrynin's report was striking in several respects. Clandestine choreography was nothing new to the White House or the Kremlin. What was remarkable was the candour with which Robert Kennedy explained the need for secrecy. The greatest difficulty for his brother, he explained, was public discussion of Turkey. 'To announce now a unilateral decision by the president of the USA to withdraw missile bases from Turkey – this would damage the entire structure of NATO and the US position as the leader of NATO … In short, if such a decision were announced now it would seriously tear apart NATO.'[66]

Since publication of Dobrynin's telegram (and the confessions of Kennedy's advisers), attention has focussed on the link between the withdrawal of the MRBMs from Cuba and the IRBMs from Turkey (and Italy). Neither historians nor Kennedy administration officials have managed to agree a term: 'secret deal,' 'offer,' 'assurance,' 'arrangement,' 'bargain,' 'secret concession,' 'hedged promise.' McGeorge Bundy described it as a 'unilateral private assurance'. May and Zelikow term it 'a unilateral statement of general intent'. Don Munton considers it a 'limited mutual missile withdrawal from allied territory of offensive nuclear missiles' which was the first-ever agreement on nuclear arms reduction.[67] As noted, Dean Rusk referred to passing 'only… information'.

There was another potentially crucial aspect of Robert Kennedy's message that also invites semantic scrutiny. RFK told Dobrynin that the US government was determined to get rid of the bases 'up to, in the extreme case, of bombing them'. If Khrushchev agreed their withdrawal, however, the blockade would be lifted, a public commitment given not to invade Cuba issued, and the missiles would be withdrawn from Turkey within four